

Lesson 06:

Seemingly Unrelated Ayat: Surah Al-Ma'idah

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Surah Al-Ma'idah is interpreted as the final address to the believers in times of ease, yet ayah 11 of this surah seems to address the believer in times of oppression. While some Orientalists argue that this ayah is unnecessary, the ayah itself makes us aware of its importance.

Surah Al-Ma'idah was one of the last surahs to be revealed. It is a Madani surah that was revealed after the conquest of Mecca.

Surah Al-Ma'idah (1-11)

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا أَوْفُوا بِالْعُقُودِ ۖ أُحِلَّتْ لَكُمْ بَهِيمَةُ الْأَنْعَامِ إِلَّا مَا يُتْلَى عَلَيْكُمْ غَيْرِ مُحِلِّي الصَّيْدِ وَأَنْتُمْ حُرْمٌ ۚ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَحْكُمُ مَا يُرِيدُ ﴿١﴾ يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا تَجَلَوْا شُعَائِرَ اللَّهِ وَلَا الشُّهُرَ الْحَرَامَ وَلَا الْهَدْيَ وَلَا الْقَلَائِدَ وَلَا آمِينَ الْبَيْتِ الْحَرَامَ يَبْتَغُونَ فَضْلًا مِّن رَّبِّهِمْ وَرِضْوَانًا ۚ وَإِذَا حَلَلْتُمْ فَاصْطَادُوا ۚ وَلَا يَجْرِمَنَّكُمْ شَنَاَنُ قَوْمٍ أَن صَدُّوكُمْ عَنِ الْمَسْجِدِ الْحَرَامِ أَن تَعْتَدُوا ۚ وَتَعَاوَنُوا عَلَى الْبِرِّ وَالتَّقْوَىٰ ۚ وَلَا تَعَاوَنُوا عَلَى الْإِثْمِ وَالْعُدْوَانِ ۚ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ ۖ إِنَّ اللَّهَ شَدِيدُ الْعِقَابِ ﴿٢﴾ حُرِّمَتْ عَلَيْكُمُ الْمَيْتَةُ وَالْدَّمُ وَلَحْمُ الْخِنزِيرِ وَمَا أِهْلَ لِغَيْرِ اللَّهِ بِهِ وَالْمُنْخَنِقَةُ وَالْمَوْقُوذَةُ وَالْمُتَرَدِّيَةُ وَالنَّطِيحَةُ وَمَا أَكَلَ السَّبُعُ إِلَّا مَا ذَكَّيْتُمْ وَمَا ذُبِحَ عَلَى النُّصُبِ وَأَنْ تَسْتَقْسِمُوا بِالْأَزْلَامِ ۚ ذَٰلِكُمْ فِسْقٌ ۗ الْيَوْمَ يَنصُرُ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا مِن دِينِكُمْ فَلَا تَخْشَوْهُمْ وَاخْشَوُا ۗ الْيَوْمَ أَكْمَلْتُ لَكُمْ دِينَكُمْ وَأَتِمَمْتُ عَلَيْكُمْ نِعْمَتِي وَرَضِيَّتُ لَكُمْ الْإِسْلَامَ دِينًا ۚ فَمَنِ اضْطُرَّ فِي مَخْمَصَةٍ غَيْرِ مُتَجَانِفٍ لِإِثْمِهِ ۚ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ رَّحِيمٌ ﴿٣﴾ يَسْأَلُونَكَ مَاذَا أَحَلَّ لَهُمْ ۖ قُلْ أَحَلَّ لَكُمْ الطَّيِّبَاتِ ۚ وَمَا عَلَّمْتُم مِّنَ الْجَوَارِحِ مُكَلِّبِينَ تُعَلِّمُونَهُنَّ مِمَّا عَلَّمَكُمُ اللَّهُ ۖ فَكُلُوا مِمَّا أَمْسَكْنَ عَلَيْكُمْ وَادْكُرُوا اسْمَ اللَّهِ عَلَيْهِ ۚ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ ۖ إِنَّ اللَّهَ سَرِيعُ الْحِسَابِ ﴿٤﴾ الْيَوْمَ أَحَلَّ لَكُمْ الطَّيِّبَاتِ ۚ وَطَعَامُ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتَابَ حَلَلٌ لَّكُمْ وَطَعَامُكُمْ حَلَلٌ لَهُمْ ۚ وَالْمُحْصَنَاتُ مِنَ الْمُؤْمِنَاتِ وَالْمُحْصَنَاتُ مِنَ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتَابَ مِن قَبْلِكُمْ إِذَا آتَيْتُمُوهُنَّ أُجُورَهُنَّ مُحْصِنِينَ غَيْرِ مُسَافِحِينَ وَلَا مُتَّخِذِي أَخْدَانٍ ۚ وَمَنْ يَكْفُرْ بِالْإِيمَانِ فَقَدْ حَبِطَ عَمَلُهُ وَهُوَ فِي الْآخِرَةِ مِنَ الْخَاسِرِينَ ﴿٥﴾ يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا إِذَا قُمْتُمْ إِلَى الصَّلَاةِ فَاغْسِلُوا وُجُوهَكُمْ وَأَيْدِيَكُمْ إِلَى الْمَرَافِقِ وَامْسَحُوا بِرُءُوسِكُمْ وَأَرْجُلَكُمْ إِلَى الْكَعْبَيْنِ ۚ وَإِنْ كُنْتُمْ جُنُبًا فَاطَّهَّرُوا ۚ وَإِنْ كُنْتُمْ مَرْضَىٰ أَوْ عَلَى سَفَرٍ أَوْ جَاءَ أَحَدٌ مِّنْكُمْ مِّنَ الْغَائِطِ أَوْ لَامَسْتُمُ النِّسَاءَ فَلَمْ تَجِدُوا مَاءً فَتَيَمَّمُوا صَعِيدًا طَيِّبًا فَامْسَحُوا بِوُجُوهِكُمْ وَأَيْدِيكُمْ ۚ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُرِيدُ لِيُظْهِرَكُمْ لِيُتَيَّمَنَ نِعْمَتُهُ عَلَيْكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَشْكُرُونَ ﴿٦﴾ وَادْكُرُوا نِعْمَةَ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ وَمِيثَاقَهُ الَّذِي وَاثَقَكُمْ بِهِ إِذْ قُلْتُمْ سَمِعْنَا وَأَطَعْنَا ۚ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ ۖ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلِيمٌ بِذَاتِ الصُّدُورِ ﴿٧﴾ يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا كُونُوا قَوَّامِينَ لِلَّهِ شُهَدَاءَ بِالْقِسْطِ ۚ وَلَا يَجْرِمَنَّكُمْ شَنَاَنُ قَوْمٍ عَلَىٰ أَلَّا تَعْدِلُوا ۚ اعْدِلُوا هُوَ أَقْرَبُ لِلتَّقْوَىٰ ۚ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ ۖ إِنَّ اللَّهَ خَبِيرٌ بِمَا تَعْمَلُونَ ﴿٨﴾ وَعَدَ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحَاتِ لَهُمْ مَغْفِرَةٌ وَأَجْرٌ عَظِيمٌ ﴿٩﴾ وَالَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَكَذَّبُوا بِآيَاتِنَا أُولَٰئِكَ أَصْحَابُ الْجَحِيمِ ﴿١٠﴾ يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اذْكُرُوا نِعْمَتَ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ إِذْ هُمْ قَوْمٌ أُنِيسُوا لَكُمْ أَيْدِيَهُمْ فَكَفَّ أَيْدِيَهُمْ عَنْكُمْ ۚ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ ۖ وَعَلَى اللَّهِ فَلْيَتَوَكَّلِ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ ﴿١١﴾

Translation

1. Believers, fulfill promises that four-legged animals have been made permissible for you to eat except for the ones that have been read onto you outside of you making things halal by hunting while you're in a state of Ihram. Certainly Allah passes verdicts as he intends.
2. Don't make permissible for yourselves violating the sanctity of the sacred symbols of Allah nor violate the sanctity of the sacred month, nor the animal that have been sacrificed nor the animals that have been marked for sacrifice, nor those that came peacefully to the sacred house that came pursuing a favor from their master and when you become halal then you can hunt and don't let the animosity you developed towards a group of people that kept you from coming to the sacred house remain, cooperate in good things and matters of piety and consciousness of Allah and don't cooperate with each other in sin and animosity, be mindful of Allah certainly Allah is intense in taking punishment.
3. Prohibited to you are dead animals, blood, the flesh of swine, and that which has been dedicated to other than Allah, and those animals killed by strangling or by a violent blow or by a head-long fall or by the goring of horns, and those from which a wild animal has eaten, except what you are able to slaughter before its death, and those which are sacrificed on stone altars, and prohibited is that you seek decision through casting lots. That is grave disobedience. This day those who disbelieve have despaired of defeating your religion; so fear them not, but fear Me. This day I have perfected for you your religion and completed My favor upon you and have approved for you Islam as religion. But whoever is forced by severe hunger with no inclination to sin - then indeed, Allah is Forgiving and Merciful.
4. They ask you what has been made lawful for them. Say, "Lawful for you are all good foods and game caught by what you have trained of hunting animals which you train as Allah has taught you. So eat of what they catch for you, and mention the name of Allah upon it, and fear Allah." Indeed, Allah is swift in account.
5. This day all good foods have been made lawful, and the food of those who were given the Scripture is lawful for you and your food is lawful for them. And lawful in marriage are chaste women from among the believers and chaste women from among those who were given the Scripture before you, when you have given them their due compensation, desiring chastity, not unlawful sexual intercourse or taking secret lovers. And whoever denies the faith - his work has become worthless, and he, in the Hereafter, will be among the losers.
6. O you who have believed, when you rise to perform prayer, wash your faces and your forearms to the elbows and wipe over your heads and wash your feet to the ankles. And if you are in a state of janabah, then purify yourselves. But if you are ill or on a journey or one of you comes from the place of relieving himself or you were intimate with women and do not find water, then seek clean earth and wipe over your faces and hands with it. Allah does not intend to make difficulty for you, but He intends to purify you and complete His favor upon you that you may be grateful.

7. And remember the favor of Allah upon you and His contract with which He bound you when you said, "We hear and we obey"; and fear Allah. Indeed, Allah is Knowing of that within the breasts.
8. O you who have believed, be persistently standing firm for Allah, witnesses in justice, and do not let the hatred of a people prevent you from being just. Be just; that is nearer to righteousness. And fear Allah; indeed, Allah is Acquainted with what you do.
9. Allah has promised those who believe and do righteous deeds that for them there is forgiveness and great reward.
10. But those who disbelieve and deny Our signs - those are the companions of Hellfire.
11. O you who have believed, remember the favor of Allah upon you when a people determined to extend their hands in aggression against you, but He withheld their hands from you; and fear Allah. And upon Allah let the believers rely.

Connection

-In Ayah 2, Allah is saying that just because the power has been flipped from your enemies to you, don't have animosity towards them like they had towards you. Don't abuse the power Allah gave you.

-In Ayah 4, Allah says that training dogs and using them as hunting dogs is allowed as long as you go by what He taught.

-In Ayah 5, Allah says if a non-Muslim invites you to eat with them you should go and eat with them and also invite them to your house to eat.

- The beginning of this surah is basically the finishing touches of Shariah. It's the final embellishments of Islamic Law. It is also like the farewell address of the Quran to the Ummah as it is one of the last surahs to be sent to humanity.
- Now that their biggest concerns (enemies, war, etc) are out of the way, they can focus on the details of Islam.
- The beginning of this Surah implies that Muslims are now in convenient times so they can focus more on their religion.
- The first 10 ayat give the finishing touches of Islam, then the surah takes a step back and says that this is part of the larger promise Allah has taken from you and the principle that drives all of this is justice. Don't let your position of power as Muslims now allow you to do injustice; be mindful of Allah, Allah is the final authority over you.
- Orientalists say that if Ayah 11 was missing it wouldn't have mattered.
- If you take out Ayah 11, the ayat before and after will still flow well together and make sense.
- Ayah 11 seems to be talking about a time when the Muslims weren't in power, so the question arises of what is the function of this ayah in this context.
- The notion that the absence of the ayah would not have been noticed, does not mean that its presence is any less profound.

- The Orientalists would say that its absence makes it unnecessary, but actually it is the opposite: the absence of something makes you unaware of its importance, it does not make it unnecessary.
- Ayah 11 has two anchors, two phrases that allude to other parts of the Quran.
 1. يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اذْكُرُوا نِعْمَتَ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ reminds us of Ayah 9 in Surah Al-Ahzab.
 2. فَكَفَّ أَيْدِيَهُمْ عَنْكُمْ reminds us of Ayah 24 of Surah Al-Fath.
- The incidents of the Battle of the Trench and the Treaty of Hudaibiyah (which are the context for the revelation of Surah Al-Ahzab and Surah Al-Fath) are referred to in Ayah 11.
- Allah is telling Muslims not to forget what it took to get to where they are now. They can't be grateful if they forget all their struggles.
- Allah is reminding them that now that they are talking about their lives as Muslims in ordinary times, they must not forget the sacrifices and the hardship that led to this.
- Islam, in the minds and consciousness of the Muslims, is not simply about observing the laws of Islam. It is about observing the laws of Islam while making the realization that it is the final gift that was paid for by the sacrifices of the early Muslims and the great favors that Allah bestowed.
- An essential part of our identity as Muslims stems from this deep connection to the struggle of Prophet Muhammad (PBUH), which can only be reached through a deep connection with the Quran itself, which is a kind of sirah of the Prophet (PBUH) from a divine perspective.
- The profound wisdom being told in this ayah is that we need to realize that the favor of Allah that has been completed (Islam being victorious and safe) should not be our only focus first; we must be conscious and grateful for how we got there.